THE BATTLE OF HANSANDO

When Japanese shogun Toyotomi Hideyoshi embarked upon the invasion of Korea in May1592, he seems to have anticipated little resistance from the Koreans at sea. His mistake was soon evident, as Korean ships inflicted heavy losses on the Japanese in a series of encounters through June and July, of which those at Okpo and Sacheon were the most notable.

As Korean naval power threatened Japanese supply and reinforcement of its land army on the Korean peninsula, Hideyoshi called on one of his boldest warlords, Wakizaka Yasuharu, to lead a counter-offensive. Wakizaka sailed from the Japanese base at Pusan with 73 ships, in search of the Korean fleet. The Koreans were equally keen on a battle. Their inspired admiral Yi Sunshin had also assembled a large fleet and was confident of victory.

Using information from local people, Yi located the Japanese fleet at anchor in Kyonnaeryang strait. He sent six ships into the strait, hoping to lure the Japanese into more open water. The stratagem worked. An impulsive, aggressive commander, Wakizaka ordered his captains to pursue the Korean ships as they fled, leading him to Yi's main fleet waiting off Hansan island. Yi had adopted a "crane's wing" formation—a U-shape designed to envelop an approaching enemy on both flanks. Wakizaka obligingly thrust his ships forward into the open trap.

Yi Sunshin's war diary
Yi recorded all the events of his career in his diary. Despite the unfair treatment he received as a result of intrigues at court, his loyalty to his king and the Korean people never faltered.



Half the Japanese ships were multiple-decked *atakebune*, the rest smaller vessels, but all were packed with fighting men, armed with bows, swords, and arquebuses. Their aim was to board Korean ships. But Yi planned to keep the fighting at a distance. Most of his ships were *panokseons*, stoutly-built galleys mounting 10 to 20 cannon on their upper decks. There were also two or three *kobuksons*, the iron-spiked vessels known as "turtle ships," that deployed even more firepower and were almost impossible to board.

> "THE REMAINING JAPANESE BOATS ... SEEING FROM AFAR THE HORRIBLE SIGHT OF BURNING VESSELS AND FALLEN HEADS, ROWED THEIR BOATS FAST AND FLED IN ALL DIRECTIONS."
>
> **YI SUNSHIN**, DESCRIBING THE END OF THE BATTLE IN HIS WAR DIARY

FALLING INTO THE TRAP

As the Japanese advanced into the "crane's wing," they became targets for ships to the front and on both sides. The Korean cannon were slow to reload, but the oarsmen kept their ships turning so that both broadsides and guns at the stem and stern were brought to bear in succession, maintaining a constant fire. The *panokseons* also carried large complements of archers, whose composite reflex bows had greater range than Japanese bows or arquebuses. Wakizara himself was hit several times by arrows, his life saved by the quality of his armor.

Inexorably the Koreans drew their formation tighter around the Japanese fleet, driving the enemy ships closer together so they could no longer maneuver and offered a dense-packed target for the gunners and archers. Incendiary weapons were also apparently used – a Japanese source speaks of "fireballs shot at our ships, which were burned and destroyed". The carnage was awesome. Several Japanese commanders committed ritual suicide aboard their sinking ships. Wakizaka was on board one of only 14 Japanese vessels to escape the scene of destruction.

The annihilation of the Japanese fleet had a decisive effect on the invasion. Unable to guarantee the seaborne supply of his army, Hideyoshi had to scale back his plans and the Japanese eventually evacuated Korea in 1593 – although Admiral Yi would be called upon to save his country from invasion again before the century's end.

JAPANESE INVASION OF KOREA



THE BATTLE OF HANSANDO

Date	August 14, 1592
Location	Off Hansan Island, Korea
Result	Korean victory

COMBATANTS

JAPAN	KOREA

COMMANDERS

Wakizaka Yasuharu	Yi Sunshin

FORCES

Ships: 73	**Ships:** 56

LOSSES

Men: 9,000 **Ships:** 47 destroyed, 12 captured	**Men:** 123 **Ships:** none

3 VICTORY IS COMPLETE
Yi Sunshin's plan works to perfection. The "crane's wing" encircles the Japanese fleet and concentrated cannon fire completes the destruction. Only 14 Japanese ships, including Wakizaka's flagship, manage to escape.

